Reflective Cover Letter

When I began working on this annotated bibliography I was generally curious about how college students change the way they write depending on who they're talking to. As I looked into the topic closely I decided to focus on audience, purpose and context. These three elements helped me narrow down my interest and better understand how they influence choices like tone, vocabulary, effort and formality. This shift gave me a path for finding sources. Looking for information on just one kind of writing I searched for studies that discussed different audiences, different writing situations and different reasons for writing. This approach allowed me to gather sources from angles.

One of the important decisions I made while building this bibliography was choosing sources that each brought something unique to my research. Some sources talk mainly about the audience while others focus more on purpose or the writing process. For example Collin gives an overview of how audience, purpose and situation shape writing. Black and Güney, Hand and McDermott each share examples of how students adjust their writing based on different audiences. Other sources like Wong and Young and Morgan helped me explore why writers make choices based on how they see their audience and purpose. Looking at all these sources together helped me notice links between the parts of my research question.

Writing the annotations also changed the way I think about using sources. At first I mainly saw the sources as information that could support my topic.. When I wrote the second paragraph of each annotation I had to think about what each source actually adds and how it connects to the other sources. I also had to consider the limits of some studies—like differences in age, background or the type of writing being studied. This made me realize that a source doesn’t have to match my research to be useful. It can still offer evidence provide a comparison or suggest an idea that helps me build my research.

This assignment shows progress toward the course goals of understanding and retoric, by having me analyse my choices, as well as find and evaluate sources. It’s about making choices—deciding which sources matter and understanding how they fit into a conversation. The annotated bibliography has given me a foundation for continuing my research, on how college students change their writing based on audience, purpose and context.

Annotated Bibliography

Black, Kathleen. "Audience Analysis and Persuasive Writing at the College Level." Research in the Teaching of English, vol. 23, no. 3, 1989, pp. 231–253. https://doi.org/10.58680/rte198915515.

Black looks at how college students use information about their audience when they write essays. The research asks if students who know more about the people they are writing for make choices in their writing. Black discovered that knowing about the audience can change the arguments students use the types of appeals they make and how they share their thoughts. This source is helpful for my research because it looks at writing done by college students and shows that understanding the audience can influence more than the tone or level of formality. It can change the content and structure of a students argument. The study gives an example of how writers might change their writing when they know more about who will read it.

This source is trustworthy because it was published in Research in the Teaching of English, a journal that focuses on writing and English education. It is very important to my research because it clearly links college students' writing choices to their understanding of an audience. One downside is that the study only looks at writing so the results might not apply the same way to personal, academic or casual writing. Still it offers proof that the audience can influence how college students express themselves. It also relates to sources like Cho and Choi and Collin which look at how audience and writing situations affect choices in writing. Black's study can help me compare audience awareness in a writing situation, with the bigger changes that students might make across different kinds of communication.

Cho, Yeonsuk, and Ikkyu Choi. "Writing from Sources: Does Audience Matter?" Assessing Writing, vol. 37, 2018, pp. 25–38. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.asw.2018.03.004.

I read the work of Cho and Choi who examine whether the intended audience changes the way students write when students use information from sources. Their study involved 205 adult English language learners who completed summary-writing tasks with either a specified audience or an unspecified audience. The researchers found that the audience affected some parts of students' writing, the amount of context students provided and how students attributed information to sources. However, the audience did not change every part of students' writing. This finding is important to my research because it suggests that the audience does not necessarily affect all writing choices in the way. Instead students may adjust features of their writing depending on what students think the

audience needs or expects. I consider this source credible because it was published in Assessing Writing, a peer-reviewed journal that focuses on writing assessment and research. I find it relevant to my topic because it provides evidence about how an intended audience can influence writing decisions. The study also gives me a comparison point because its participants were adult English language learners rather than traditional college students in general. That difference is a limitation when applying the findings directly to my research. However it also makes the source useful for considering how background and writing experience may affect audience awareness. I see a connection with Black and Collin because all three suggest that the audience can influence decisions while also showing that the effects may be limited to certain parts of a text.

Collin, Ross. "How Rhetorical Theories of Genre Address Common Core Writing Standards." Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy, vol. 57, no. 3, 2013, pp. 215–222. https://doi.org/10.1002/JAAL.221.

Collin discusses how rhetorical theories of genre can explain how writers respond to writing situations. The article points out that writers choose based on audience, purpose, task and context. Of seeing genres as strict templates Collin sees them as tools that help writers fit to particular situations. Collins view is useful for my research because Collins view gives me a way to understand why students write in ways in different settings. A student might use a tone when writing an email to a professor, a more organized format, for an assignment and a relaxed style when messaging a friend. Each of these situations brings its expectations and goals that shape the way the student writes.

This source is trustworthy because it is in the JAAL which is legitimate and peer reviewed for its literacy. It fits my research because it shows a way to think about how audience, purpose and context influence rhetorical decisions. One downside is that the article is more theoretical than experimental. It doesn't include student writing samples or data unlike some of my other sources. It still helps me understand the ideas behind the writing patterns I might observe. It also helps connect the other sources I'm using. Many of them look at one factor at a time—like motivation or identity. Collin brings those factors together by showing how they work in writing situations. That makes the whole picture clearer.

Güney, Murat, Brian Hand, and Mark Andrew McDermott. "Writing for Different Audiences: Effects on High-School Students' Conceptual Understanding of Biology."

Learning and Instruction, vol. 19, no. 4, 2009, pp. 354–367. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.learninstruc.2008.07.001.

Güney, Hand, and McDermott examine how writing for different audiences affects students' understanding of biology. The study involved 118 high-school students who wrote about biology for different audiences, including teachers, younger students, peers, and parents. The researchers found that the intended audience affected the way students approached the writing task and could also influence their understanding of the subject. This source is useful because it shows that changing the audience can affect more than the surface features of writing. The audience can change how writers organize and think about information. Although the study focuses on high-school students and biology rather than college students, it provides an example of how the audience can affect both writing behavior and the writer's thinking.

This source is credible because it was published in Learning and Instruction, a scholarly journal that focuses on educational research and learning processes. It is relevant to my research because it provides direct evidence that students change their approach when writing for different audiences. The main limitation is that the participants were high-school students and the writing tasks were connected to biology, so the results may not transfer directly to college writing in other subjects. However, that difference can actually be useful for my research because I can compare the findings with studies involving college students. This source connects with Black and Cho and Choi by showing that the audience can affect specific writing choices, while also supporting the broader idea that writing is influenced by the situation in which it occurs.

Wong, Albert T. Y. “Writers’ Mental Representations of the Intended Audience and of the Rhetorical Purpose for Writing and the Strategies That They Employed When They Composed.” System, vol. 33, no. 1, 2005, pp. 29–47. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2004.06.009.

Wong examines how writers think about their intended audience and rhetorical purpose while composing. The study focuses on four advanced second-language writers who used think-aloud methods while completing writing tasks. Wong found connections between how the writers understood their audience and purpose and the strategies they used while composing. The writers did not simply produce a text and then consider the audience afterward. Their understanding of the audience and purpose was part of the writing process itself. This source is useful for my research because it helps explain why students may change their writing when the audience or purpose changes. It suggests that audience awareness can influence decisions while a writer is actively planning and composing a text.

This source is credible because it was published in System, a scholarly journal focused on language learning and communication. It is relevant because it examines the mental and strategic side of adapting writing to an audience and purpose. A major limitation is the very small sample size of four writers, which means the findings cannot easily be generalized to all college students. However, the detailed focus on the writers' composing strategies gives the study a different kind of value than larger studies. It can help me think about the reasons behind writing choices rather than only looking at the final text. This source also connects with Collin because both emphasize audience and purpose as factors that shape the writing process, while Wong provides more direct evidence about how writers think through those factors.

Young, Debra Dimond, and Rachel Morgan. "The Impact of Critical Community-Engaged Writing on Student Understanding of Audience." Composition Studies, vol. 48, no. 3, 2020, pp. 35–52. https://eric.ed.gov/?id=EJ1283209.

Young and Morgan examine how community-engaged writing affects college students' understanding of the audience. The article compares writing for authentic community purposes with more traditional academic writing. The authors discuss how students can view academic writing as something they produce mainly to demonstrate a skill for a professor, while community-engaged writing can give them a clearer sense that their writing is meant to accomplish something for an actual audience. The source is useful to my research because it shows how the perceived purpose and reality of an audience can affect the way students think about their writing. It also raises the possibility that students may put different levels of effort or attention into writing depending on whether they see the audience as real or simply part of an assignment.

This source is credible because it was published in Composition Studies, a scholarly journal in the field of composition and rhetoric. It is relevant to my research because it focuses directly on college students and their understanding of audiences in different writing contexts. The article is especially useful for considering the difference between writing for a grade and writing for a genuine communicative purpose. A limitation is that community-engaged writing is a specific type of course activity, so the findings may not describe every kind of college writing. Still, the source provides a useful perspective on how purpose and audience can change students' attitudes toward writing. It connects with Collin's discussion of rhetorical situations and with Black's work on how audience awareness can affect college writing choices.